



Staying Safe in the Workplace

As the owner of a business, you have a legal responsibility to protect staff, customers, and clients from harm. Proper safety procedures will help your operations run smoothly, avoiding accidents and injuries.

Creating a safe work space

It is vital to protect your staff and visitors while they are in the workplace. Check with government and local authorities for the legal safety requirements applicable to your workplace (see pp.212–215). A hairdresser, for example, will present different hazards from those in a garage or tech start-up. Almost all types of business premises—from a home office or studio, where clients

or contractors may visit, to a retail location or a manufacturing facility—need to meet basic obligations in order to keep workers and visitors safe. Carry out risk assessments and act on any issues that arise, instruct staff on safety procedures, and ensure that all equipment is installed correctly and regularly maintained. Safety precautions also help protect your premises and assets from damage due to accidents.

Protecting yourself and others

When planning or setting up a workplace, pay attention to these key areas to protect yourself and those working for you or visiting your premises. You could be prosecuted if your working conditions are found to be dangerous.



Hygiene

Provide regularly cleaned toilets with soap and handwashing and drying facilities, as well as bins for secure waste disposal. If you offer hospitality services, you may need extra hygiene measures.



Food handling

Be sure staff involved in the preparation of food are trained to meet the legal requirements for food hygiene and storage, the proper cleaning of utensils and equipment, and pest control measures.



Fire

Follow government and local directives on the fire safety responsibilities of landlords and commercial tenants. Appoint key employees as fire marshals; hold regular emergency drills for all staff.



Toxicity

Avoid harm to people and animals by preventing their exposure to chemical or gas toxins, such as asbestos, cleaning agents, and machine fumes. Follow local regulations for the disposal of toxic waste.